A brief resume would explain all the interest. Set up in 1870 by Sir Henry Daly, the Political Agent of Malwa, the institution moved into its present 118-acre Indore campus in 1912. Among its alumni, count former chief minister Digvijaya Singh, economist Prabhat Patnaik, US-based orthopaedist Dr Chitranjan Ranawat, the state's top mandarins (including Neeraj Mandloi, additional chief secretary to the CM), besides a gallery of former ministers and legislators like Surendra Singh 'Honey' Baghel, Sachin Yadav, Sudesh Rai and Brijendra Pratap Singh aka 'Dau Saheb'.

ELECTION HEAT

Given that spread, it would be tempting to read the conflict as reflecting a wider one between an old elite and its would-be gatecrashers—and any potential change being a blow to the *ancien régime*. But that could be simplistic in this case. The reason is more banal: the board is slated for elections in December and it's the usual scrimmage for turf. The good part: it would, at least theoretically, take Daly's administration towards greater accountability.

The board has two elected members from among the category of old donors, mostly former royals who had contributed financially in setting up the school. Two elected members come from among the alumni, one from among the 'new donors'. Two government and parent nominees each, the latter appointed by the board once constituted, complete the club of nine. The Principal comes in as an ex-officio secretary.

Presently, both government nominees are coloured royal blue: president of the board Vikram Sinh Puar and vice-chairperson Rajyavardhan Singh, who are the titular maharaja of Dewas and the ex-raja of Narsinghgarh, respectively. Rounding off that part of the spectrum from the old donor category are Narendra Singh and ex-minister Priyavrat Singh, of the peerages of Jhabua and



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Chairman, Daly board

Khilchipur, respectively. Harpal Bhatia represent the new donor category; Sanjay Pahwa and Sumeet Chandhok (since resigned) are the parent nominees. But much of the feuding begins with the two elected from the ranks of alumni: Parekh and Dheeraj Lulla, who are mostly at daggers drawn with each other. Sources say irrespective of who holds the chair, it's Lulla who calls the shots in board meetings. In effect, he faces only one dissenting voice—that of Parekh.

The assistant registrar's order endorses a few big demands, mandating a wider representation in Daly College Society, the registered body under which the school and other affiliated institutions run. The former students and new donors, too, must be given place on it, it says, while laying down norms for a clearer oversight.



Takeaways

- **An assistant registrar orders school to amend its governing rules**
- **Provokes wide debate among Daly's illustrious alumni—a gallery of former royals, netas like Digvijaya Singh, and top mandarins**

Puar, though, had an interesting counter. "The order seems prima facie unconstitutional," he says, confirming that a legal challenge is in the works. "How can one society be ordered to become the member of another society?"

He also rubbishes talk of arbitrary administration. "Among all public schools in the country, Daly College has elections, which makes it one of the most democratic schools in the country in its functioning," Puar points out, adding an irony-laden barb: "At times, this provides for an opportunity to those with vested interest to sully the image of the school but democratic functioning has numerous advantages for which it should be cherished."

A FUND OF VALUES

What's at stake is not abstract values like old-world esteem. The school income from fees and deposits touches Rs 95 crore; add to that a comparable reserve fund. Allegations of opaque, whimsical running have been aired, including by Parekh in a letter to the board where he stated that meetings were not held properly, with minutes.

More recently, the head girl of the school resigned with a blaze of bitter complaints against the administration. That led to a counter-attack—by her own peers and classmates. It was amidst this letter war that parent nominee Chandhok quit the board. All stakeholders are hoping for the best, whichever way the case goes. There's some agreement on the fundamentals, though. "Transparency is the key to upholding Daly's reputation," said senior advocate Ajay Bagadia, an old student, at the Indore High Court. ■